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Breaking the line: Wong May's postcolonial and exophonic Chinese mobilities

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ABSTRACT
This article explores the postcolonial and exophonic mobilities of Wong May, who studied and wrote at the University of Singapore and the Iowa Writers' Workshop, and has lived and worked in Ireland since 1978. Her poetic trajectory brings together influences from the British literary Movement in the 1950s, and late Anglo American modernism combined with her aesthetic Chineseness. The article further discusses how she may in turn have contributed to the evolution of modernist objectivism and open form through her poetic friendship with the American poet Hilda Morley. Wong's mobile postcolonial Chinese poetics arguably disrupts and transforms both the multicultural management of postcolonial Singapore and American modernist manifestos on Chinese poetry and projective verse. By reading the "Afterword" to Wong's collection of Tang poetry translations against her own poems, this article argues that Wong's distinctive brand of objectivism results in a non-partisan ethics of minor disruption that expands readings of postcolonial aesthetics.

KEYWORDS
Wong May; Hilda Morley; modernism; exophony; aesthetic Chineseness; Singapore

Introduction: Exophonic trajectories

In 1966, Wong May, a young Chinese female poet working at Federal Publications in Singapore, wrote to Paul Engle, director of the Iowa Writers' Workshop: "I want desperately to go away. I'll never become *real here*, and I can't stand my own unreality" (Wong 1966b, n.p.; emphasis in original). By 1967, Wong had left for Iowa, and in 1969 her first poetry collection, virtually unchanged from the thesis submitted in fulfilment of the master of fine arts at the University of Iowa, was published in New York by Harcourt, Brace & World as *A Bad Girl's Book of Animals*. Born in Chongqing, China, she "grew up in Singapore" (flyleaf of *Superstitions*) and since 1978 has resided in Dublin. Wong went on to publish three other poetry collections – *Reports* (Wong 1972), *Superstitions: Poems* (Wong 1978), and *Picasso's Tears: Poems, 1978–2013* (Wong 2014) – and a volume of translations of Tang poetry, *In the Same Light: 200 Tang Poems for Our Century* (Wong 2022). That same year she was the recipient of Yale University's Windham-Campbell Prize for Poetry in 2022. Writing on topics as wide-ranging as Pablo Picasso's (1937) painting *Guernica* and the 1974 famine in Bangladesh, she has earned a reputation for

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capturing the mobile zeitgeist of the late 20th century (Tse 2023, 21). The small but growing body of scholarship on her work continues to draw attention variously to her cosmopolitanism, statelessness, and ecological modernism (Ang 2025; Leow 2010; Whitehead 2017). Wong's oeuvre demonstrates a mobile aesthetics that disrupts the racialization of linguistic categories by the postcolonial state,[1] while refusing a transnational modernism anchored in the Global North.

Wong's trajectory weaves together the heady decolonial years of Singapore in the mid-1960s, and a broader sociocultural shift towards the development of local style and subject matter in English-language poetry in Malaya; parachuting into Iowa introduced her to US counter-culture of that moment. During these same years she was also in touch with a circle of late-modernist American poets who had taught at Black Mountain College in North Carolina. In the late 1960s and early 1970s, Wong's writing was closely associated with Hilda Morley's, from the same circle. Her poetic blueprint reaches back into her formative years in Singapore. Educated in Chinese-medium schools until senior high, her transition into anglophone writing began with preparatory classes for the University of Singapore, where she completed a bachelor of arts degree in English literature in 1965 (Tse 2023, 12). As she writes her poetry in English rather than her mother tongue, Wong can be described as an exophonic poet, but she also remains mobile between both languages, often reading and writing poetry in an interlingual mode.

In this article, I examine the mobility of Wong's Chineseness and how it informs her anglophone poesis, treating her "Afterword" to *In the Same Light* as a critical exegesis of her exophonic poetic method in her poetry collections, published earlier. An attentive discussion of Wong's exophony as an energetic conduit between Singapore and the USA pries open the linguistically segregated and effete English poetic scene in 1960s multilingual Singapore, and adds to the late-modernist aesthetic conversation on line breaks, breath, and the plasticity of verse form. While aware of the extensive scholarship on Chineseness and its diverse sociopolitical contexts in Southeast Asia, it is the intention of this article to prioritize aesthetic concerns rather than favouring the social analysis more commonly found in postcolonial treatments that neglect literary readings (Ashcroft 2015, 412). Taking my cue from a description of Wong as "a Chinese poet-friend, who writes in English" in a letter from her friend Hilda Morley to John Lucas (Morley 1985), this article asks what happens to Chineseness when it is aesthetically distanced from majoritarian notions of racialized, national, or linguistic membership. By doing so, this article theorizes an aesthetics of Chineseness transposed into anglophone modernism, placing Wong in association with Ezra Pound and Charles Olson, but also Han Suyin and contemporary British Chinese poets, such as Sarah Howe.[2] Such mobility is also aligned with recent archipelagic approaches to reading literature and culture in Southeast Asia, where locations, such as Singapore in Wong's verse, are referenced multiply and comparatively in a manner that obviates nation- and language-centric parameters in literary readings (Chan 2023; Lee 2023; Gonzago 2024; Poon 2024).

While Wong would not be regarded as a postcolonial poet in Singapore's national tradition, her trajectory from Singapore to the USA, and finally to Dublin, allows her to write poetry that carries influences from the classical Chinese tradition into wider anglophone networks of poetic study and creation. Such mobilities would not have been possible without her attendance at the University of Singapore, an English-

medium institution operating at variance with current developmental tendencies towards indigenization and cultural development in the region. The appearance of new literary works in English at that time, within a polylingual environment, exerted an effect of defamiliarization that revealed the interstitial presence of other racial and linguistic categories, while also unsettling their formation (Holden 2009, 21). In the multilingual milieu of 1960s Singapore, new literary works appeared in both English and other ethnic languages, indicating how literature of the period did not necessarily stem from an ethnonationalist response in support of non-colonial languages (Poon 2010, 31). By contrast, reading Wong's ethics in her critical reflections about poetry, in conjunction with her own writing, allows a consideration of how postcolonial approaches can extend to exophonic writing and mobile disruptions of linguistic and cultural disciplining.

Far from being an exception, exophony in fact typifies the writerly experience for a large number of authors who move to other countries, and for writers who choose to write or self-translate into other languages. Exophony also includes pseudo-exophonic writers – those who know enough about another language to collaborate with translators, but without full fluency (Johnson 2023, 710). Exophonic writing is marked by linguistic defamiliarization in a manner distinct from mere defamiliarization in terms of subject matter; it can feature textual composition in more than one language, or the conventions of multiple writing systems. Moreover, the term "exophony" focuses on a linguistic state of being rather than the writer's background (Wright 2008, 39). In my approach to reading Wong's Chinese mobility, exophony is further understood as the poet's critical appraisal of poetic features in modernist poetry in terms of Chineseness, rather than simply interlingual encounters between two languages.

Distinct from a Eurocentric history of progress, Tang modernity produced the verses of classical Tang poets, who broke away from the state and "forged a more direct poetics of the personal" (Friedman 2015, 192) in the late 7th and 8th centuries following the An Lushan rebellion and other challenges to the central imperial government. Wong's retrospective claim on these same writers can be treated as a modernist mobility that draws Chineseness into a contemporary anglophonic and exilic mode. Her cosmopolitan approach, mobile across Singapore and America, resonates historically with how the prosody of Tang poetry draws from Sanskrit metre and the śloka in particular (Mair and Mei 1991, 382). Weihsin Gui (2017) suggests that "such transplantations of modernisms in the Malayan-Singaporean context create a representational space" (2) with further ethical and political valences. By rejecting a diffusionist model of modernity from Europe, literary writing becomes "a space of possibles", where the grounding context or event is not the defining context of a work's critical reception (3). While the Southeast Asian modernist networks of Nanyang style painters in Singapore have been discussed in this vein (Tan 2023, 5), less attention has been paid to Southeast Asian anglophone writers with sinophone beginnings.

In the same spirit, this article functions as an exophonic excursion through Wong's poetry. By tracing the evolution of specific elements of poetic style, namely an objectivist emphasis, imagistic juxtaposition, line breaks and open form, and perspectival defamiliarization, a case can be made for the mobility of poetic features in Southeast Asian and modernist writing through the exophony of Chineseness into anglophone verse. Ezra Pound was famously dubbed "the inventor of Chinese poetry for our time" by T.S. Eliot (1948, 14), and Wong gamely extends this comment

a century later, dubbing Pound "the inventor of Chinese poetry in the English language", despite her departure from his methods (Wong 2022, 360). Distinct from Pound's imagism, Wong's objectivist poetics transplants postcolonial Singapore's intermingling of stylistic influences into American modernism. The article discusses the sociopolitical ethics implicit in Wong's self-described poetics, where a spirit-filled objectivist focus on things refuses co-option into majoritarian ethnic, linguistic, and national categories.

Expanding imaginaries: Beyond the university circle

An autonomous anglophone poetic tradition in Malaysia and Singapore began with student publications in early university-based journals such as the *New Cauldron* at the University of Malaya (renamed in 1962 as the University of Singapore). Poets from the 1950s and 1960s who published in these journals, such as Wang Gungwu, Edwin Thumboo, Lee Tzu Pheng, Robert Yeo, and Arthur Yap, are canonized as pioneering poets in Singapore writing (Wong 2009). Wong first published English verse in 1963 in *Focus*, a university student magazine. Her later work from this period appeared in *The Flowering Tree* (Thumboo 1970) and *The Second Tongue* (Thumboo 1976), the first anthologies of Malaysia and Singapore anglophone poetry, and internationally in the literary magazines *The American Scholar* and *Poetry Australia*, and the poetry anthology *New Voices from the Commonwealth* (Thumboo 1970, 1976; Sergeant 1968; Wong 1966a). Writing and publishing at a moment when Singapore had just attained political independence, Wong could be variously classified as Chinese, Malayan, Singaporean, or internationalist due to both languages that she wrote in, the poetic styles she subscribed to, and the publication outlets for her work.

For this reason, Wong's poetic style in her pre-Iowa poems reveals the mobility of anglophone poetic elements developing into an exophonic mode, a feature noted by earlier Singapore critics. Robert Yeo (1986) notes how, in her poem "The Shroud", Wong "intensely conveys" the melding of past and present through "repetition, and specific, universal imagery" – images that escape social or cultural connotations while remaining particularist (61). Her "universal imagery" distinguishes her from contemporaries like Yap and Chandran Nair, whose work was strongly specific to place and ethnic culture, respectively. By contrast, Wong is removed from an immediate responsiveness to her postcolonial location in Singapore in terms of social or political vision, while possessing "a definite niche" for style and subject matter (Yeo 1986, 61). Yeo's initial formal observations stand in contrast to Thumboo's attempt, in his introduction to *The Second Tongue*, to locate the poets of this period within a postcolonial trajectory of cultural development and increasing independence from British literary tradition. Thumboo is hard-pressed to locate Wong within such a narrative. Elsewhere, he wishes for "a more normal focus, a larger share of the ordinary reality" in her poetry (Thumboo 1973, xix) that he fails to find with Wong's tendencies towards defamiliarization and objectivism, which are detectable even at this stage.

Wong's final poem for *Focus*, "Chips, Not Pearls" (Wong 1967), provides an initial glimpse into her mature style. It takes the primary form of a narrative from the perspective of a stone mermaid carved onto a tomb awaiting her long-lost prince who has been imprisoned. In this poem a defamiliarizing and particularizing perspective

emerges through the passive voice, that in turn renders an objectivist minimization of voice, ego, and character:

> The stones clang and ring and purr
> under chisels held by strong-veined arms
> And a spark is suddenly beaten
> into a mermaid's eyes
> (Wong 1967, 9)

The latent violence of being carved, in fact, "beaten" into life, yet dead to any form of spontaneous self-will, is conveyed in the sea-maiden's voice, when she laments how "too long a palpitating waiting / can make a stone of a mermaid" (Wong 1967, 9). The successive stresses on the words in the first phrase show mastery of the line, while the mermaid's testimony, referring to herself in the third person, expresses the quiet tragedy of unrequited love.

At the University of Singapore, Wong came under the tutelage of the Movement poet D.J. Enright, who published in the university student journal *Focus* and brought out four poetry collections during his time in Singapore. His career outside Britain, and subsequent stylistic development, set him apart from other British poets such as Philip Larkin and Thom Gunn. However, his writing during this period is characteristic of the Movement poets (Bradley 1993, 53) whose work collectively exhibits "a new poetic emphasizing clarity, intellectual detachment, and formal perfection" with a "wry honesty" that made them sceptical about the seriousness of poetry (3). His appointment as professor of English from 1960 to 1970 at the University of Singapore allowed him to open doors to the Anglo American poetic scene for students like Wong and he encouraged her to apply to the Iowa Writers' Workshop (Tse 2023). Conscious of her relatively recent exophonic foray into anglophone poetry which began only in her first year at the university, she tells Enright in a preliminary exchange of letters: "Give me 10 years, I'll show you what I can do in English" (recounted in a letter to Paul Engle; Wong 1965a). In the same letter to Paul Engle, Wong exclaims: "I need to be transplanted if anything is to come out of me at all." Wong's desire to leave Singapore can be understood as an extension of her earlier exophony into English, and to escape from her mother's domineering presence as a Chinese poet.[3] In his recommendation letter, David H. Rawlinson (n.d.), a lecturer in English at the University of Singapore, observes how "Miss Wong was developing a feeling for the language which people entirely educated in English do not always possess", pointing to how her poetic talent was recognized as being extra-anglophone. Wong had read many of the primary Anglo American modernists at university in Singapore, but proposed a course of research at Iowa that would cover "poetry as a world movement" relating to the anxieties of bridging east and west, with "the Malaysians likely to form a new synthesis" (Wong 1966a, n.p.). Exophony for Wong, at this initial stage, meant a meeting point between different poetic traditions in the postcolony of Malaysia.

Reading Wong's pre-Iowa writing against Enright's yields a renewed perspective on anglophone aesthetic mobility that does not cohere with Thumboo's developmental view of an autochthonous poetic tradition that begins with a localization of style and subject matter. Koh Tai Ann (1981) observes that the desired independence of local Singapore poets from wider English traditions as a decolonizing mode was complicated by a competing impulse to be understood as "literary" through these same western literary standards. Unlike accounts that begin the national tradition of anglophone poetry writing

with Singapore's pioneering poets, Koh makes a case for formalistically connecting Thumboo, Lee, Yap, and Yeo to Enright's clarity of statement, witty word play, and disciplined emotion – poetic elements which are also discernible in Wong's pre-Iowa poems. Enright's suspicion of populist sentiment – for example, his criticism of the Singapore government's cultural policies, and his privileging of an individualist, organic mode of culture – also became something Wong adopted aesthetically in her wry but universalist satire.

Wong takes from Enright the scepticism of extreme emotion, and an inclination towards lucidity and non-partisan humanism. Comparing the style of Enright's contemporaneous poems in *Unlawful Assembly* (Enright 1968) with Wong's last poems published when she was resident in Singapore yields significant parallels with Movement poets, particularly in the use of the statement and the aphorism. In the poem "Brief Briefing", Enright combines the imagist's attention to denotational colour, with aphoristic statements that extend into symbolism and political allegory. The poem opens: "Colourful? It's green here, / Green and green. And then / A spectrum of ideologies –" (1968, 23). In Singapore, "too much green" must be curbed in favour of "grey apartment houses" (Enright 1968, 23), a clear reference to the rapid expansion of high-rise public housing estates in the 1960s, but perhaps also an implicit comment on the suppression of Malayan communist guerillas in the jungles. The final stanza describes "the flags of washing / streaming out from poles" (23) evoking the irrepressibly colourful image of laundry flapping in the wind along the flank of these grey flats.

"Study of a Millionairess: Still Life" by Wong emulates Enright's use of the statement and image, but develops these further to express an unsparing satire of filial piety within a Chinese family. The poem depicts a paralysed and wealthy matriarch, whose family is gathered around her, preparing crabs for a feast. The opening stanza begins with instructions to "pluck away all its fingers and legs / we only want the crab's face which is its torso" (Wong 1965b, 12). The following lines equate the crab shell to the "unbroken mask" of the millionairess, whose rapidly blinking but "lashless eyes" are all that remain to convey a signal (12). None of the family notice her trying to speak, and she is as immobile as the crab that she watches her family dissect. Later, they devour it on this occasion of the Prosperity Goddess. The deity's favourite colour is red, and the poem's last lines read:

> The aged are supposed to be like the Goddess
> to be feasted and fed on the colour of the heart
> while the two lashless eyes
> signalling and signalling
> are red and tired
> (Wong 1965b, 12)

The pronouncement about how the elderly should be treated recalls Enright's declamatory stance towards green ideology, as does the direct denotative mention of red that ironically triangulates the female deity, the "colour of the heart", and the matriarch's bloodshot eyes. However, the startling imagistic equating of the paralysed crab and the old woman's desperately still face is rendered with a vividness that is almost vicious. Wong's restrained but emotionally sonorous lines bring together the technical coolness of the Movement and a fearsome gravitas of situational satire, where Chinese reverence for the elderly merges into indifference.

Though Koh calls "Study of a Millionairess: Still Life" a "most Chinese poem" (1965b, 168), it is arguably not so in terms of realism or local colour, neither does any part of the poem indicate an ethnic identification of the family as Chinese. Instead, we see the mobility of Wong's Chinese sensibility into a modernist anglophone mode, exophonically governed by the development of the line. This is not based on the syllable as a unit and the termination of breath at the line's end, as Charles Olson (1967, 56) defines it, but the starkness of imagistic contrast as juxtapositional breakage – where Chinese elements such as the matriarch and the Prosperity Goddess are disquietingly and surrealistically presented. Instead of folding Wong's achievements into a lineage of poetic influence from the Movement, here the line is broken in two ways. First, an exophonic departure from the Chinese poetry of Wong's youth: second, with a further aesthetic transmutation when Chineseness, removed from racialized or linguistic frames in postcolonial Singapore, is presented using anglophone poetic elements adapted from the mid-century Movement.

Shen-Qi 神气: The exophonic animation of American objectivist poetics

Containing a selection of classic Chinese poetry translated and mobilized for the 21st century, Wong's (2022) edited anthology *In the Same Light* features well-known names such as Du Fu and Li Bai from China's initial Golden Age, but also Bai Ju Yi and Yuan Zhen from the Age of Recovery writing after the An Lushan Rebellion and the restoration of the Tang imperial lineage in AD763. The volume also contains a 100-page "Afterword" by Wong, ostensibly to explain her translational approach. Titled "The Numbered Passages of a Rhinoceros in the China Shop", it transcreates the conventional English idiom of the bull in the china shop, bringing together the Tang mythos of the rhinoceros as "an original spirit" and Wong's thoroughly eclectic treatment of Chinese poetics. The "Afterword" consists mainly of short poetic treatises as well as extended essays which feature Wong's own comparative hermeneutics of Chinese terms such as Shen-Zhi (神志) or consciousness, which she links to the integrity of poetic knowing, or Wen-Ming (文明) or civilization, that she compares to the European Enlightenment. Shen-Zhi (神志) and Wen-Ming (文明), in turn, are freed from and mobile beyond the constriction of a singular historical context.

Replete with references to Wong's upbringing under her Chinese poet mother, Wong's "Afterword" also ventures a comparative treatment of the role of poetry in society between Tang China and the modernist west, discussing the place of breath and breathing patterns in the poetic line, the nature of poetic knowing, and the "thing-like" nature of Chinese nouns in the form of Chinese characters, alongside the depersonalization of the natural landscape. *In the Same Light* (Wong 2022) is inscribed in the epigraph as being "From the Migrants & Exiles of the Tang Dynasty", a deliberate redeployment of contemporary transnational terms in English – Wong would probably consider herself one of them. The "Afterword", however, also reads as a critical praxis of the mobility of aesthetic Chineseness that may be used as a rubric to assess Wong's poetic intersections with Pound's imagism, and the projective verse of Olson, as well as influences from Morley, known for her clarity of line and luminosity of form (Hilda Morley n.d.).

An argument for the exophony of Wong's Singapore-originating, prior Chinese sensibility entering into the US space of the Iowa Writers' Workshop can be made, not only on

the basis of her correspondence, but also in the distinct parallels and departures between the "Afterword", and her developing style in *A Bad Girl's Book of Animals* (Wong [1969] 2023). In this first collection, she pares down further the narrative and descriptive aspects of verse, and trains the focus of many poems on an object framed and sharpened by aphoristic statements to convey a heightened symbolism. In "The Chinese Written Character as a Medium for Poetry", initially attributed to Ezra Pound, but originally composed by Ernest Fenollosa, the pictorial nature of Chinese characters is understood as the process of metaphor in "the use of material relations to suggest immaterial relations" (Fenollosa and Pound 2008, 54). Calling these "primitive metaphors", Fenollosa and Pound suggested that these follow "objective lines of relations in nature itself" (54). As a pseudo-exophonist not wholly fluent in Chinese, Pound attends more to the plasticity and visual form of Chinese, and in his long poem *The Cantos*, where he includes Chinese characters, radicals are translated independently of their originating Chinese character, to extrapolate further meanings (Pound [1925] 1989).

By comparison, the sound and semantics of Chinese characters were always transparently integral to Wong as she wrote her poems. In the "Afterword", she describes how a "Chinese ideogram exudes *time*, each is a construct, the components are fitted together as an entity (infrangible)" ([1969] 2023, 369; emphasis in original). She explains now that one learns how to use the Chinese language by "recognizing the sign, a sign identical with the concept" (369). The thing-like collapse of the ideogram-into-ideated concept is a way of understanding Wong's own brand of objectivism that contracts away from wider ideological and civilizational frames as exophonic Chinese words are so impenetrably thing-like they break the hold of majoritarian appropriation. Poems in Wong's first collection take an animal or object, such as dogs in "The Judgment" and eggs in "Eggs", and metaphorize psychological and emotional conundrums through object-relations centred on these.

For example, in "To Be Buried", the embedding of a stone in a peach becomes a confrontation with the persistence of death in life, and of life in death, since the speaker's mother lives on in her. The final two stanzas read:

> Mama as in the peach
> a stone there is, so
> You in me (flesh) and
> I in you (earth)
> Simply dead
> (Wong [1969] 2023, 74)

The metaphorical equivalence of mother-and-daughter with peach-and-stone, alongside the tautological equivalence of proceeding clauses, apprehends the daughter's numb dying into her mother's death. Both are "simply dead" and have become stone-like and earth-like, unlike the peach of longevity in Chinese mythology. In the "Afterword", Wong expounds on how the Chinese language is "blessedly uninflected" by tense, number, and gender. It is a "taciturn, forgiving tongue" ([1969] 2023, 376) and in a regulated Tang poem, the "nouns are lozenges, hard boiled-sweets, verbs acting on their own" (377). This thing-like constriction stands in contrast to Pound's treatment of Chinese ideographs as condensations of noun–verb relations through a pictorial combination of radicals which convey a vivid "*verbal idea of action*" expressive of Pound's theory of the sentence as a primitive, cross-civilizational poetic unit (Fenollosa and

Pound 2008, 45; emphasis in original). By comparison, Wong prioritizes the metaphorization of things as psychological states, which are demetaphorized in further psychosocial assemblages – the double movement of thing-into-metaphor and vice versa. Such stylistic features can be treated as the exophonic mobility of Chineseness into her first collection, and the late modernist and anglophone space of mid-century Iowa.

Wong's poetry was also shaped by her friendship with Hilda Morley, which began after she completed her MFA (master of fine arts) at Iowa, and when both attended the same artist residency at the MacDowell Colony in 1968. Though Morley only published her first collection at the age of 60, her third collection, *To Hold in My Hand: Selected Poems 1955–1983* (Morley 1983), contains many poems dated precisely to the first years of their friendship. Although there is no exchange of letters between the two poets available for consultation, a firm trace of this reciprocal influence remains in poems dedicated to or addressed between Morley and Wong. In her poem titled "Apprenticeship with Hilda Morley", published in *Superstitions*, Wong evokes their mutual commitment to the "Unhallowed Art" of poetry and describes her friend as one who is burned alive by the "fire" of grief following her husband's death (Wong 1978, 121). In a signature move of metaphorical extension through object relations, Wong calls this flame

> A rag
> to wipe the
> Face with
> A face to
> Burn away
> or the Grief a soiled
> shirt worn
> Much worn, must
> too be rejected, conjured
> Away
> (1978, 121)

This appearance of open form, with its cascading line breaks, also occurs in Morley's poems from the late 1960s. Her mastery of spacing, breath unit and line breaks is conventionally traced to Olson (Levertov et al. 1982, 21) whom she met through the Black Mountain circle of poets, and to his manifesto on projective verse including his notion of "composition by field", where poets generate a poem's open form through a kinetic series of perceptions (Olson 1967, 2).

However, Morley's and Wong's poetic friendship and mutual influence also began contemporaneously with a shared attention to objectivism in their poems. An impulse carried from Singapore days in Wong's style, this focus is also present in Morley's earliest poems. In the *Ironwood* appreciation issue dedicated to Morley's career, she inscribes the first poem, "Sea Lily", "For Wong", signalling the influence of her poet-friend on her beginnings as a poet (Morley 1982, 9). This inscription did not appear in the poem's first publication in *To Hold in My Hand* (1983). Although clearly alluding to H.D.'s poem of the same title and mirroring its Grecian simplicity and attention to a flower's visual form (Doolittle and Martz 1983, 14), Morley's poem's central pivot is between the "cup" of the lily, opened by the pulse of water, to an inner "cup/of fullness" which takes "from whatever passes / giving / itself away" (1982, 9). In comparison to Wong's stark, sometimes harsh, object-relations by metaphor and

juxtaposition, Morley's poesis results from repetition leading to an association across two different objects. Nonetheless, the central emotional tenor of many of their poems derives from a similar objectivist transposition, and throughout their lifetime, both poets would publicly signal this exchange. Morley's poem "For Wong May" was published in her first collection (Morley 1983, 12), and Wong is also mentioned in Morley's elegiac poem for Olson (Morley 1983, 22). In the former, Morley portrays Wong preparing "meals / in the colour of Chinese landscape paintings" in her New York kitchen as a parallel to the precision in her friend's poetic craft. Each component of the meal is

> savoury
> & exact in separateness,
> as she is
> in her words, no waste in her
> and moving in ways most needful, only
> (1983, 12)

In the interview appended to *Picasso's Tears* (Wong 2014), Wong has only two words for Morley as a poet and person: "Praise Be" (n.p.). Her elegy for her friend also appears in the same volume and is titled "To Hilda Morley 1919–1998". In the poem, Wong picks damsons and addresses Morley posthumously through the event of "A tree deserving of your poetry / Your treatment" (Wong 2014, 80). In the simplicity and poignant fullness of a tree as thing-which-is-living, Wong pays homage to a sister poet whose craft illuminates, through close and depersonalized attention, the poem's object.

The poetic exchange between Wong and Morley reveals a number of suggestive parallels between Wong's mobile Chinese aesthetics and the modernist milieus in which Morley moved. At Black Mountain College, and in the post-war US avant-garde more generally, there was a surrealist investment in the graphic and glyphic with a focus on the ideograms and hieroglyphs of Chinese and Mayan cultures (Byers 2018, 97). These pictograms were important for their plasticity and indecipherability; their supposed primitivism advanced a "plain and blunt witnessing" (98) in response to the political disillusionment of Roosevelt's New Deal, where leftist and working-class organizations no longer found traction with broader public discourse (98). Olson draws a connection between concept, breath, and line break, while also insisting on the paring down of description, such that the open form of a poem becomes a "series of objects in field in such a way that a series of tensions (which they also are) are made to hold" (1967, 56). However, as discussed, Wong's objectivism derives, at least in equal part, from the mobility of Chinese poetics centred on the statement and thing-like nouns, as well as an emotional circumspection from Enright. In her essay "Organic Form", Morley cites Olson's theory of breath and line breaks, and makes a further refinement concerning what she calls "the poet's personal voice […] that inward noise that makes use of intensely personal rhythms" (2002, 326). Crucially, the poet's private voice is to be distinguished from the public verse and metered stresses of Pound's *The Cantos* (Morley 2002, 326). Further ideological distinctions can also be discerned in Pound's Confucian-derived portrayal of the duty-bound individual integrated into social order (Lan 2005, 110). Wong adopts a similar stance to Morley in maintaining that poetry is "more of a question of temperament/

sensibility/style than ethnicity" (2014, n.p.), that can be understood as an aesthetic refusal of continental notions of Chinese identity and majoritarian formations of belonging.

In her "Afterword", Wong observes that "every poet has a distinct breathing pattern" ([1969] 2023, 353). Poesis resides not in what the words say but in Shen (神), because the poem is the result of Shen-Qi (神气) or spirit. Not exactly the form, sense, or concept of the words, Shen-Qi is an "infrangible" combination that animates the poem "akin to *élan*, to *verve*" (353; emphasis in original). Quoting Confucius's three-word definition of poetry, Shih Yan Zhi (诗言志, which can be directly translated as "poetry speaks the will"), Wong explains how poetry articulates an untranslatable notion of Zhi, the closest being the Greek *arete* for both "excellence and knowledge" (395). "Words ring true only with Zhi", Wong notes, when self-possession is restored to the word, alongside a dignified presence of things and beings, without excessive recourse to the subject or ego – the aesthetic pearl seed of an ethical or social vision (395). Line breaks and breathing patterns in open form, in Wong's mind, cannot be treated as mere visual or plastic form – the exophonic poem is not a mere object because it is spirit-filled, though it should be objectivist.

Throughout her poetic career, this shadow-knowledge of Chineseness is present in Wong's anglophone poetry. The poem titled "Zhi Liao" (知了) in *Picasso's Tears* evokes the cicada, as well as the act of knowing. However, "Zhi Liao" (知了) appears nowhere in the poem as Chinese characters, leaving the husk of two transliterated words "Zhi Liao". In summer, the incessant call of cicadas mimics this transliterated sound stripped of its original Chinese form, which becomes an allegory for Wong's exophony, where she "listen(s) with 2 ears / At 2 telephones" (2014, 205). Frustrated with what she hears, and the demand it makes for the listener to know, she slyly reveals the modernist ignorance of homophony in Chinese by juxtaposing both "know" and "zhi". Closer to e.e. cummings than to Ezra Pound, she writes:

> Cicada in Chinese sings:
> Know/Known/Known? – know – Known
> Knoooooooooow, now
> Zhi- *liao* –
> Zhi – *liao* – zhi – zhi – *liao*
> Zzz – zzz
> No – – ah (2014, 207)

Among such "ceaseless enquiring / Ceaseless sounding" one never finds a final answer in "the alarming world" (2014, 209). English words obliquely broken apart as sound reveal Chinese dimensions of meaning, and Wong's mobility of modernist aesthetics has come full circle, from her initial sinophone exophony into anglophone writing, and now in reverse. This multidirectional modernist array, which sounds-and-sights its sense, exemplifies the playfully rich interplay of objectivist aesthetics first suggested in Wong's and Morley's friendship.

Conclusion: Postcolonial mobilities and exophonic ethics

Anglophone postcolonial poetry has been described on a developmental continuum, where resisting the mimicry of colonial forms leads to the indigenization of English in the form of new literatures in postcolonies, in a process of "dialectical play between assimilation and resistance, or dependency and the will-to-autonomy" (Patke 2006, 4). Wong's exophony, by contrast, is based on a rubric of mobility between languages, a poesis sprung from her dual apprehension of sinophone and anglophone poetics. Rather than a literature springing from a social or cultural impulse of resistance, however defined, Wong's ethical protests seem eclectic for their choice of subject matter. Joanne Leow (2010, 54) identifies "East Bengal" as an exceptional poem in Wong's second poetry collection *Reports* (Wong 1972) for its focus on the poverty and political injustice of the 1971 Bangladesh famine; an observation supported and elaborated upon by Angus Whitehead (2010, 31), who recognizes the importance of opening up Wong's poems to political and biographical references. In her third collection, *Superstitions* (Wong 1978), this sociocultural focus is further emphasized in a number of poems such as "Europe", where "class is race" (46); poems that reference the learning of English, including "Budapest, May 72" (59); and a spotlight on minor figures such as the Algerian garbage-man in "Morning in Grenoble" (61) and the child in Singapore squatting on the toilet floor in "1944–1976" (122). Wong trains "a cosmopolitan lens on an increasingly complicated world" (Whitehead 2017, 38), as a poet of "lost-ness" characterized by "a series of migrations and leavings" (Lim and Tse 2022, n.p.) and features subject matter from the broad swathe of the second half of the 20th century and into the 21st.

Throughout her oeuvre, Wong's objectivist focus on colours, animals, and things presents poetry as an aesthetic and spiritual home without the coerciveness of essentializing or generalizing categories. What, then, could constitute Wong's exophonic ethics, even if she cannot be described as postcolonial in relation to a specific country or nation? In the *Picasso* interview, Wong writes that she cannot think of "consciousness" and "conscience" as "two separate departments" (2014, n.p.). Instead "each word is a moral decision", in response to the urgent anguish that she feels "about the world" (n.p.). She reflects on the beauty of children in refugee camps, and how they become "mothers of bombs & martyrs" (n.p.). In her poems, the concern with objectivist form and the "loveliness" of such children resists being co-opted into an identitarian speaking position, while conveying the horror and tragedy of their circumstances. The epigraphs to the "Afterword" expand her objectivist minimalization of cultural belonging and political formations into the mobility of exile, and the necessity of translation in the condition of migration, taken as they are from the biblical book of Ezekiel, the Syrian poet Ali Ahmad, W.G. Sebald, and Rumi. The quote from Ezekiel concerns the speaking that becomes possible only with hospitality towards the fugitive; while Ahmad's equates the translated poem with the "migrant / living in an alien house" (2022, 8). Alienation is a condition of translation, but it enables, and is enabled by, a mobility of hospitable ethics – one that has issued forth from Tang modernity. Rather than the potentially homogenizing construct of a cosmopolitanism located in the global north, or a lost-ness centred on permanent exile, Wong's ethics of exophony implies a pervasive disruption of majoritarian raciolinguistic and cultural categories, minoritizing both English and Chinese literatures as anglophone and sinophone writing.

Throughout, this article has traced Wong's postcolonial and exophonic Chinese mobilities through several anglophone nodes. Her mobile postcolonial Chineseness exerts a disruptive transformation of both postcolonial Singapore's multicultural framework as well as American modernist manifestos on imagism and projective verse. Instead of a poesis of line-breaks and visual poetry based on syllables, breath, and the pictorial vividness of Chinese ideograms, Wong's objectivism strips image and form of expressiveness. Her poetics restores the possibility of universalism to the human subject where even postcolonial dialogues are riven by sectarian debates. Possessing a radical exophony that reinterprets Confucius's Shih Yan Zhi (诗言志), Wong's poetic method demonstrates how Chinese poetry in English speaks of the ethical will in terms of an aesthetic crossing, and 志 (zhi) in this transformed sense.

Notes

1. Wong first published her work in Singapore, where an official policy of multiracialism based on the founding ethnicities of the postcolonial nation on the model of Chinese, Malay, Indian, and Other was aligned with Singapore's four official languages, Chinese, Malay, Tamil, and English (Goh 2009, 3).
2. Han Suyin is a Eurasian doctor whose fiction and non-fiction on Malaya and mainland China provided western audiences with a window on post-war China; and Sara Howe is a British Chinese poet born in Hong Kong, whose anglophone verse inventively employs Chinese sounds and characters. Wong can be considered further in comparison with these other female Chinese writers whose work mediates between Chinese culture and a broader anglophone audience.
3. Wong's fraught relationship with her mother shapes her relationship with poetry. Describing how her mother "always held [her] in her mouth, like a fiercely maternal animal", not swallowing her entirely, or letting go, Wong (2014, n.p.) has declared poetry to be her "Mother Tongue" instead.

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